# Approach #2: Contextualized

Contextualized training is one of the hallmarks of Skills for Success. This approach ensures learning is relevant to participants' work, learning and life goals. In Skills for Success programs, contextualization often focuses on participants' intended occupations. The focus is on building practical skills and knowledge that can be applied in real-world, on-the-job situations. Training activities incorporate authentic materials, tasks and scenarios to maximize transfer of learning to the workplace.

## Impact: Why use this approach?

A contextualized approach can have a significant impact on the effectiveness of training, enhancing the relevance of the learning experience to participants' career and life goals. This, in turn, increases their motivation and engagement, resulting in greater skill gains. By centering the learning around workplace-based tasks, participants feel better prepared to apply their new knowledge and skills on the job, leading to improved job performance and career prospects.

**Key Terms Defined**

**Authentic materials:** Learning materials that replicate real-world situations, tasks and scenarios that participants may encounter in the workplace, training or daily life.

**Competency-based training:** A training approach that emphasizes the development of specific competencies, or sets of knowledge, skills and abilities that are required to perform a job or task effectively.

**Occupational and industry standards:** Established criteria for the knowledge, skills and abilities required to perform specific jobs or tasks, often developed and maintained by industry organizations or government agencies.

**Transfer of learning:** The extent to which participants are able to apply the knowledge and skills learned in the training to their work or life context.

**Workplace-based tasks:** Training activities that are designed to replicate or simulate tasks that participants are likely to encounter in their workplace. Also called *performance-based* tasks when they are used for participants to demonstrate their knowledge and skills.

## Training Applications: What does this look like in the training room?

Practitioners can apply a contextualized approach to Skills for Success training by incorporating the following practices:

- Conducting a needs assessment to identify the specific learning needs and goals of the participants and their relevance to their work or intended occupation.
- Incorporating workplace-based tasks, scenarios and materials into the training to help participants develop practical skills and knowledge that can be applied on-the-job.
- Aligning the training content and objectives with industry and occupational standards to ensure that participants are learning skills and knowledge that are relevant and necessary for their field.
- Providing opportunities for participants to reflect on their progress and make connections between the training and their career goals.
- Incorporating role plays, simulations or case studies that replicate real-world situations and challenges participants may encounter on the job.
- Helping participants access networking opportunities to connect with other professionals in their field, such as through mentorship programs or industry events.

**Engagement**

Coordinate with sectoral organizations and employers to align training with skill needs in the workplace.

*Implementation Guidance (p. 107)*




**Practitioner Competency Framework**

- SFS 2.2 Contextualizes Skills for Success training to make learning relevant and practical
- SFS 2.3 Applies a competency-based approach to Skills for Success training
- DESIGN 1.3 Conducts needs analysis with various training partners to inform Skills for Success design
- DELIVER 2.1 Makes learning relevant to participants
- ASSESS 4.3 Evaluates transfer of learning from training to workplace

## Special Note: Authentic Materials

Authentic or workplace documents are the emails, standard operating procedures (SOPs), entry forms, schedules, diagrams, codes, regulations, schematics tables, reports and graphs that workers use on the job. Workplace documents may consist of continuous text, a mix of text and graphics, or just graphics.

Using authentic documents allows practitioners to target and contextualize instruction. Participants are more engaged when materials are contextualized to the workplace they are in or to the occupation they are interested in.

Here are some tips to help you find and gather workplace materials for your training programs:

- **Engage with Subject Matter Experts:** Connect with professionals working in the field relevant to your training. They can provide insights into the types of documents commonly used and share resources or contacts that might have access to authentic materials. Leverage your network and training partnerships.
- **Professional Associations and Organizations:** Many industries have associations and organizations that publish reports, guidelines, training materials and other relevant documents. Scan their websites to see what is available. Follow up directly for specific material requests. Organizations may be willing to share their resources for training purposes.
- **Government and Regulatory Bodies:** Government agencies often publish official documents related to regulations, standards and safety practices.
- **Company Websites:** Companies often publish reports, case studies, research findings and policies on their websites. Look for the "Resources," "Publications," or "Research" sections on company websites.
- **Industry Journals and Magazines:** Trade publications, industry journals and magazines often feature articles, case studies and real-world examples that can serve as valuable authentic materials.
- **Social Media and Online Communities:** Join online forums, groups and social media platforms related to the industry. Engaging with professionals in these communities can lead to the discovery of valuable resources.
- **Networking:** Attend conferences, workshops, seminars and networking events relevant to the industry. These events provide opportunities to connect with practitioners and obtain authentic materials.
- **Collaborate with Employers:** Build relationships with employers in the industry you're targeting. They might be willing to share internal documents, case studies, or training materials for educational purposes.
- **Request Permissions:** If you come across relevant documents that are copyrighted or not publicly available, consider reaching out to the authors or organizations for permission to use them in your training materials.
- **Academic Partnerships:** Collaborate with universities, research institutions, or educational organizations that focus on the relevant industry. They might have access to valuable documents through their research networks.

**RESOURCES:**

Use these resources to help you contextualize training programs for a wide variety of occupations (Transferable), sector-specific contexts (Construction, Manufacturing, Tourism) and underrepresented groups (Indigenous people, racialized Canadians, members of the LGBTQ2+ community, newcomers, neurodiverse learners, and people with disabilities).

## Transferable

- Employment and Social Development Canada. (n.d.). *Welcome to the occupational and skills information system (OaSIS).* https://noc.esdc.gc.ca/Oasis/OasisWelcome?GoCTemplateCulture=en-CA
- Government of Canada. (2023). *Essential skills profiles.* Job Bank. https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/essentialskillsprofilelist/A
- National Center for ONET Development. (n.d.). *ONET OnLine*. https://www.onetonline.org/

## Construction Sector

- Build Force Canada. (n.d.). *Build force Canada.* https://www.buildforce.ca/en
- Canada's Building Trades Unions. (n.d.). *Canada's building trades unions.* https://buildingtrades.ca/
- Canadian Council of Directors of Apprenticeship. (n.d.). *Red seal program*. https://www.red-seal.ca/
- SkillPlan. (2023). *Learning hub.* https://skillplan.ca/learn/

## Manufacturing Sector

- Canadian Manufacturers & Exporters (n.d.). *Canadian manufacturers & exporters.* https://cme-mec.ca/
- Canadian Manufacturing (n.d.). *Canadian manufacturing.* https://www.canadianmanufacturing.com/
- Excellence in Manufacturing Consortium (n.d.). *Excellence in manufacturing consortium.* https://emccanada.org/
- Government of Canada. (2021). *Canadian manufacturing sector gateway.* https://ised-isde.canada.ca/site/canadian-manufacturing-sector-gateway/en

## Tourism Sector

- Destination Canada. (n.d.). *Destination Canada*. https://www.destinationcanada.com/en
- Government of Canada. (2023). *The Canadian tourism sector.* https://ised-isde.canada.ca/site/canadian-tourism-sector/en
- Tourism HR Canada. (n.d.). *Tourism HR Canada*. https://tourismhr.ca/
- Tourism Industry Association of Canada. (n.d.). *Discover tourism*. https://discovertourism.ca/

## Underrepresented Groups

### General underrepresented groups

- Frkovic, R. (2022). *Empowering unique learners for college success.* Fanshawe College Pressbooks. https://ecampusontario.pressbooks.pub/empoweringuniquelearnersforcollegesuccess/
- SRDC. (2022). *Skills for success implementation guidance*. Final report. https://www.srdc.org/media/1945054/skills-for-success-implementation-guidance-final-report.pdf

### Indigenous learners

- Alberta Regional Professional Development Consortium. (2018). *Weaving Ways: Indigenous Ways of Knowing in Classrooms and Schools.* https://empoweringthespirit.ca/wp-content/uploads/2018/09/Weaving-Ways-Introductory-Document-10-09.pdf
- Antoine, A., Mason, R., Mason, R., Palahicky, S., & France, C. R. de. (2018). Pulling together: A guide for Indigenization of post-secondary institutions. https://opentextbc.ca/indigenizationcurriculumdevelopers/
- Queen's University Library. (2023). *Resources for Decolonizing your Teaching.* https://guides.library.queensu.ca/decolonizing-resources

### Members of the LGBTQ2+ community

- ABC Literacy. (2023). *How to make an inclusive classroom for 2SLGBTQI+ learners.* https://abclifeliteracy.ca/blog-posts/how-to-make-an-inclusive-classroom-for-2slgbtqi-learners/
- Centre for Innovation in Campus Mental Health. (2022). *Invisible intersections: Supporting 2SLGBTQ+ students on campus.* Canadian Mental Health Association. https://campusmentalhealth.ca/wp-content/uploads/2022/12/CICMH-2SLGBTQToolkit_v2.pdf
- Government of Manitoba. (2017). Supporting transgender and gender diverse students in manitoba schools. Manitoba Education and Training. https://www.edu.gov.mb.ca/k12/docs/support/transgender/full_doc.pdf
- University of British Columbia. (2020). Towards more trans-inclusive classrooms: An introduction. https://ctlt-inclusiveteaching.sites.olt.ubc.ca/files/2020/01/trans-inclusive-classrooms_v2.pdf

### Neurodiverse learners and people with disabilities


- CAST. (2018). Universal Design for Learning Guidelines version 2.2. https://udlguidelines.cast.org
- LD OnLine | All About Learning Disabilities and ADHD. (n.d.). https://www.ldonline.org
- Neurodiversity Hub - Resources for Universities. (n.d.). https://www.neurodiversityhub.org/resources-for-universities
- Takacs, D. S., Zhang, J., Lee, H., Truong, L., & Smulders, D. (2021). A Comprehensive Guide to Applying Universal Design for Learning. In opentextbooks.uregina.ca. BCcampus. https://opentextbooks.uregina.ca/jibcudl/


### Newcomers and racialized Canadians


- ABC Life Literacy. (2023). How To Support Black Learners In Your Literacy Program | ABC Life Literacy. ABC Life Literacy Canada. https://abclifeliteracy.ca/blog-posts/how-to-support-black-learners-in-your-literacy-program/
- Ho, J. (2022). Anti-Racism and Inclusive Excellence: Recommendations for Teaching and Learning. UBC Centre for Teaching, Learning and Technology. https://ctlt.ubc.ca/2022/10/18/edubytes-anti-racism-and-inclusive-excellence-recommendations-for-teaching-and-learning
- Shaibah, A. (2022). Building a Race-Conscious Institution: Enacting Anti-Racist Organizational Change Universities Canada -1. https://www.univcan.ca/wp-content/uploads/2022/07/UC-2022-Report_Building-a-Race-Conscious-Institution_EN_FINAL.pdf
- Stewart, J., Martin, L. (2018). Bridging Two Worlds: Supporting Newcomer and Refugee Youth. CERIC. https://ceric.ca/publications/bridging-two-worlds-supporting-newcomer-and-refugee-youth/

# Approach #3: Complexity

In Skills for Success training, the complexity or difficulty of learning tasks and materials are aligned to participants' needs and goals. Through needs analysis, including job task analysis and pre-assessment, data is gathered and used to identify differences between participants' starting levels and required levels of their intended occupations. Practitioners guide participants through progressively more complex tasks to help them reach the target skill level.

## Impact: Why use this approach?

Creating learning materials and activities at the appropriate complexity level provides participants with a level of challenge that is motivating but not overwhelming. This approach increases participants' confidence by providing instructional support and strategies that address their specific learning needs. Participants feel more engaged and supported throughout the training process, resulting in step-by-step progress towards their learning and occupational goals.

**Key Terms Defined**

**Complexity:** A task's level of difficulty. Skills for Success are necessary for every job, but the skills are used at different levels of complexity depending on the demands of the job.

**Closing skill gaps:** Reducing the difference between a participant's current skill level and the required skill level for a particular goal or occupation.

**Job task analysis:** Using data to determine the appropriate complexity level of skills required for specific occupations.

**Mastery:** the ability to perform a task or skill at a consistently high level of proficiency.

**Needs analysis:** A systematic process of identifying the specific needs of an individual, group or organization, often by gathering data through surveys, interviews and observations.

**Pre-assessment:** An assessment that is administered at the beginning of a learning experience to measure learners' starting level of knowledge, skills and abilities and identify any gaps or areas of need.

**Scaffolding:** Providing instructional support and interventions to help participants progress through progressively more complex tasks.

## Training Applications: What does this look like in the training room?

Practitioners can align complexity to participants' needs by using the following practices:

- Conducting job task analysis to identify the appropriate complexity level of skills required for specific occupations.
- Gathering pre-assessment and needs analysis data to identify the gaps between the participants' starting levels and required levels of skill.
- Becoming familiar with the complexity levels of the Skills for Success and Essential Skills Frameworks, gaining awareness of the gradations between each level.
- Creating learning activities and materials at a variety of complexity levels to accommodate individual participants' needs and abilities.
- Gradually increasing the complexity level of learning activities and materials to help participants progress towards mastery.
- Pinpointing where participants are struggling in the learning process and offering appropriate supports, feedback and guidance.
- Continuously monitoring participants' progress and adjusting instruction accordingly to ensure that the complexity level remains appropriately challenging but not overwhelming.
- Helping participants gain awareness of the language and criteria of relevant proficiency levels, including those used in the Skills for Success and Essential Skills frameworks.
- Encouraging participants to reflect on their learning and progress and providing opportunities for self-assessment and self-reflection.
- Offering timely and constructive feedback to help participants improve their skills and build confidence.
- Helping participants develop mastery by providing opportunities for practice, reinforcement and application of their skills in real-world contexts.

**Engagement**



Clearly link assessments to learning goals and activities, and prioritize collecting participant information in a directed, purposeful manner.

*Implementation Guidance (p. 124)*




**Practitioner Competency Framework**

- SFS 2.3 Applies a competency-based approach to Skills for Success training
- SFS 2.4 Varies complexity of learning tasks and materials to align to participants' Skills for Success needs and goals
- SFS 2.5 Applies instructional scaffolds to help participants progress
- DESIGN 1.3 Conducts needs analysis with various training partners to inform Skills for Success design
- ASSESS 1.1 Bases assessment framework on program goals, industry standards, learning outcomes and participant needs

**RESOURCES:**


- Human Resources and Social Development Canada. (2010). *Reader's guide to essential skills profiles.* Government of Canada. http://en.copian.ca/library/learning/hrsdc/guide/guide.pdf

- Lew, J., & Hardt, M. D. (2011). *Controlling complexity: An introduction to question structure.* SkillPlan. https://skillplan.ca/learn/product/controlling-complexity/

- SRDC. (2021). *Research report to support the launch of skills for success: structure, evidence and recommendations. Final report.* https://srdc.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/07/sfs-srdc-final-report-en.pdf




# Approach #4: Direct Instruction

Direct instruction is a clear and explicit approach to teaching that breaks down concepts into smaller parts and steps. Instruction is delivered through demonstration and guided practice, gradually moving towards more independent learning and application. Learning is carefully sequenced, giving participants time to develop mastery of foundational skills and knowledge.

## Impact: Why use this approach?

Direct instruction makes the learning process clear and manageable. By ensuring participants understand what to do and reducing misinterpretations, instruction and learning is more efficient. Breaking up learning into smaller steps can also help lighten the cognitive load, freeing up working memory to better understand and retain new knowledge and skills. Participants with learning differences and disabilities may particularly benefit from this approach.

**Key Terms Defined**

**Chunking:** Breaking down complex information into smaller, more manageable parts to aid in processing and retention.

**Cognitive load:** The amount of mental effort required to process information.

**Guided practice:** Providing opportunities for participants to practice the skill or concept with structure, support and feedback.

**Learning outcomes:** Clear and specific statements that describe what learners are expected to know or be able to do as a result of the learning experience.

**Mastery:** The ability to perform a task or skill at a consistently high level of proficiency.

**Scaffolding:** Providing instructional support and interventions to help participants progress through progressively more complex tasks.

**Sequencing:** The process of organizing instruction, concepts or skills in a logical order to facilitate learning.

## Training Applications: What does this look like in the training room?

Practitioners can apply a direct instructional approach by incorporating the following practices:

- Identifying the information, skills and knowledge that are critical for participants to learn.
- Planning a logical sequence of lessons by considering the necessary prerequisite skills and knowledge and progression of difficulty.
- Looking for ways to break down complex information and processes into smaller chunks and steps that participants will be able to understand and follow.
- Structuring the learning process by giving models, scripts, templates and step-by-step processes for participants to follow.
- Beginning lessons by clearly stating the lesson's goals and expectations and making sure the content of the lesson stays aligned to these goals.
- Reviewing instructions before an activity and asking questions afterwards to check for understanding.
- Using demonstrations to provide instruction and verbalizing the thinking process through each step.
- Providing ample opportunity for participants to practice using new skills in a structured way, gradually reducing the amount of guidance and support.
- Giving immediate feedback during learning activities so that participants don't practice the wrong way.




**Practitioner Competency Framework**

- SFS 2.5 Applies instructional scaffolds to help participants progress
- SFS 2.6 Provides direct instruction to structure and guide Skills for Success learning
- DELIVER 3.2 Structures and scaffolds delivery to maximize learning

**RESOURCES:**


- Archer, A., & Hughes, C. (2011). *Explicit instruction: Effective and efficient teaching*. Guilford Press.
- Calvin, S. (2019). *Planning & teaching explicit instruction*. LD@school. https://www.ldatschool.ca/planning-teaching-explicit-instruction/
- Hughes, C. A., Morris, J. R., Therrien, W. J., & Benson, S. K. (2017). *Explicit instruction: Historical and contemporary contexts: Learning disabilities research*. Learning Disabilities Research & Practice. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/318176128_Explicit_Instruction_Historical_and_Contemporary_Contexts_LEARNING_DISABILITIES_RESEARCH

# Approach #5: Assessment

Skills for Success training programs include a mix of formative and summative approaches to assessment. Assessment is used to measure specific learning outcomes, provide feedback to participants and guide instructional decisions. A pre-assessment is typically used before training begins to identify participant needs and a post-assessment is administered after training to measure results. Transfer of learning is another measurement that is used to evaluate the overall effectiveness of Skills for Success training.

## Impact: Why use this approach?

Out of all the instructional approaches, assessment has the greatest impact on learning. Assessment provides opportunities for participants to receive feedback on their progress and to identify areas where they need further development. Practitioners can use assessment to monitor participants' progress and adjust instruction to meet their needs. Evaluating training effectiveness can help training organizations improve the quality of future training programs. Overall, effective assessment practices lead to improved learning outcomes, increased skill gains and a stronger workforce.

**Key Terms Defined**

**Authentic assessment:** Assessment that requires learners to demonstrate their understanding and skills in real-world or meaningful contexts.

**Formative assessment:** Ongoing monitoring of participant learning and feedback that can inform both instructors and participants on how to improve. Typically used throughout the training program and doesn't include formal grades.

**Learning outcomes:** Clear and specific statements that describe what learners are expected to know or be able to do as a result of the learning experience.

**Post-assessment:** An assessment that is administered at the end of a learning experience to measure learners' understanding and skills after they have completed a course or program.

**Pre-assessment:** An assessment that is administered at the beginning of a learning experience to measure learners' starting level of knowledge, skills and abilities and identify any gaps or areas of need.

**Skill gains:** The progress that learners make in acquiring new knowledge and skills as a result of participating in a learning experience, which can be measured through assessment.

**Summative assessment:** Used to measure participant learning at the end of a training program or significant learning period. Summative assessment is used to evaluate participants' achievement of learning outcomes and determine formal marks or grades.

## Training Applications: What does this look like in the training room?

Practitioners can integrate effective assessment in Skills for Success training by applying the following practices:

- Establishing clear and measurable learning outcomes and aligning assessments with them.
- Using a mix of formative and summative assessments to measure progress and performance.
- Providing timely and constructive feedback to learners to reinforce positive performance and identify areas for improvement, focusing on the areas that are most critical for success.
- Administering pre- and post-assessments to measure the effectiveness of the training program and identify areas for improvement.
- Incorporating authentic assessments that require participants to demonstrate their knowledge and skills in real-world or workplace-based contexts.
- Offering opportunities for self-assessment and reflection to encourage participants to take ownership of their learning and identify areas for growth.
- Incorporating a variety of assessment methods (e.g., quizzes, role-playing, projects) and modes (e.g., written or oral) to engage learners and accommodate different learning needs.
- Ensuring assessments are fair, valid and reliable, and that they measure what they are intended to measure.
- Collecting and evaluating post-training feedback from participants, employers and other training partners, using data to make program improvements.




**Practitioner Competency Framework**

- SFS 2.7 Incorporates ongoing formative assessment and feedback to track progress of Skills for Success outcomes
- ASSESS 1.1 Bases assessment framework on program goals, industry standards, learning outcomes and participant needs
- ASSESS 1.2 Incorporates a variety of assessment types into assessment framework
- ASSESS 2.1 Uses pre-assessment results to adapt instruction and curriculum
- ASSESS 2.2 Uses formative assessment to inform instruction
- ASSESS 3.2 Encourages participants to self-reflect on their own progress and achievement
- ASSESS 4.3 Evaluates transfer of learning from training to workplace

**RESOURCES:**


- Center for Educational Research and Innovation. (n.d.) *Assessment for learning formative assessment.* OECD. https://www.oecd.org/site/educeri21st/40600533.pdf

- Bin Mubayrik, H. F. (2020). New trends in formative-summative evaluations for adult education. *SAGE Open 10(3).* https://doi.org/10.1177/2158244020941006

- Davies, N. (2021). *What learning evaluation model should you really be using?*. https://thinqi.com/resources/blogs/what-learning-evaluation-model-should-you-really-be-using

- SRDC. (2023). COMSA Survey Builder. https://measurement.srdc.org/

# Approach #6: Social-Emotional Skills

The Skills for Success framework includes the social-emotional and soft skills of Problem Solving, Communication, Collaboration, Adaptability and Creativity & Innovation. These skills also play an important role in learning the core literacy skills of Reading, Writing and Numeracy, as well as Digital skills. Whereas Section 3 provides skill-specific instructional strategies, this section provides guidance on how to approach Social-Emotional Learning (SEL) as a whole, including how it can be integrated into any skills training.

As opposed to fixed personality traits, the Skills for Success framework defines social-emotional skills as teachable, learnable skills that can be improved through targeted training interventions.

## Impact: Why use this approach?

Social-emotional skills play a critical role in the success of training participants, impacting their performance in work, learning and life. As the Canadian workplace evolves and becomes increasingly automated, social-emotional skills are especially important and support job transferability and employment resiliency. Defining social-emotional skills as teachable and learnable helps empower participants to develop and enhance these skills, rather than feeling confined to a fixed pre-disposition. Strong social-emotional skills also facilitate the acquisition of other skills, such as literacy in a training context and technical skills on the job. Ultimately, social-emotional skills equip individuals to effectively respond to challenges and address issues in a constructive manner, fostering resilience and perseverance rather than giving up easily. Incorporating SES into the instruction of other skills allows participants to practice the complex and integrated nature of workplace tasks.

**Key Terms Defined**

**Emotional intelligence (EQ):** The ability to identify, understand, manage and effectively use both one's own emotions and those of others to navigate social interactions and build positive relationships.

**Growth mindset:** The belief that abilities and intelligence can be developed and improved through effort, learning and perseverance, rather than being fixed traits.

**Self-reflection:** The practice of examining one's thoughts, feelings and actions to gain insight into one's behavior, motivations and values, aiding in personal development.

**Self-regulation:** The ability to manage and control one's emotional responses and reactions in a way that promotes constructive and adaptive behavior.

**Self-validation:** A mindset where individuals seek to validate their existing skills and abilities rather than focusing on self-improvement or change.

**Social-emotional learning (SEL):** The process through which people acquire and apply the knowledge, skills and attitudes to develop healthy identities, manage emotions and achieve personal and collective goals, feel and show empathy for others, establish and maintain supportive relationships and make responsible and caring decisions (CASEL, 2023).

## Training Applications: What does this look like in the training room?

Practitioners can apply effective social-emotional and soft skills instruction in Skills for Success training by incorporating the following practices:

- Pre-assessing participants' current social-emotional skills and needs and using that information to tailor the program effectively.
- Clearly defining the social-emotional and other skills that are the focus of the training and establishing specific goals that are both attainable and challenging.
- Motivating participants by involving them in setting their own goals, fostering commitment and promoting ownership of learning.
- Helping participants see the value in social-emotional training by ensuring they understand the connection between social-emotional skills and broader educational, organizational and personal goals.
- Providing frequent opportunity for participants to practice using social-emotional skills in training activities that replicate real-world conditions as closely as possible. Where possible, incorporate practice and observation of behaviours outside of the training room in an authentic context.
- Incorporating enough repetition of contextualized practice to help participants develop and strengthen their skills and improve transfer to the workplace.

- Balancing favorable and unfavorable feedback, without favoring positive feedback to the extent that learners do not receive critical feedback needed for improvement.
- Offering mentorship and coaching opportunities to provide personalized guidance and feedback.
- Fostering a self-improvement or growth mindset in participants by teaching them to respond adaptively to constructive feedback, persist and make efforts to change and improve their performance.
- Offering support and guidance to individuals who may withdraw from challenging tasks due to negative self-perception or fear of failure.
- Creating a supportive and inclusive learning environment where learners feel safe to take risks, make mistakes and learn from them.
- Modeling of effective social-emotional skills by the practitioner, demonstrating positive behaviours for participants to emulate, both inside and outside of the training room (e.g., in the hallway, lunchroom, etc.).
- Providing opportunities for participants to engage in self-reflection and recognize their strengths and areas for growth in their social-emotional skills.
- Integrating social-emotional skills into other skills training, such as providing explicit instruction on effective collaboration to support interactive activities in reading or numeracy training.

**Engagement**

Facilitate safe learning spaces, while building key social emotional skills to support resilience.

*Implementation Guidance (p. 110)*




**Practitioner Competency Framework**

- SFS 2.1.4 Integrates multiple Skills for Success into learning tasks to reflect the integrated nature of workplace tasks
- SFS 2.8 Supports social-emotional well-being to develop self-regulation skills
- DELIVER 1.2 Creates an atmosphere that addresses the social-emotional needs of participants
- DELIVER 1.3 Builds participants' confidence and ownership of learning process
- ASSESS 2.3 Encourages participants to self-reflect on their own progress and achievement

## Special Note: Evergreen Section

The content on social-emotional skills training and instruction is subject to ongoing updates as the Office of Skills for Success refines skill components and assessment criteria to align with the evolving research in this field.

**RESOURCES:**


- CASEL. (2023). Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning. CASEL. https://casel.org
- Conference Board of Canada. (2023). *Can social and emotional skills be taught?* Conference Board of Canada. https://www.conferenceboard.ca/wp-content/uploads/2022/10/can-social-and-emotional-skills-be-taught.pdf
- Futureworx.(2024). ESAT Employability Skills Assessment Tool. https://futureworx.ca/employability-skills-assessment-tool/
- Gibb, Stephen. (2014). Soft skills assessment: theory development and the research agenda. *International Journal of Lifelong Education*. 33. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/263702987_Soft_skills_assessment_theory_development_and_the_research_agenda
- Learner Variability Navigator. (n.d) *Adult Learner Strategies.* Digital Promise. https://lvp.digitalpromiseglobal.org/content-area/adult-learner/strategies

## Section 3

# Skill-Specific Instructional Strategies

This section focuses on specific instructional strategies for each of the nine Skills for Success. Read an overview of each skill and its components, learn how to implement the top evidence-based instructional strategies for the skills and consider factors for assessment. Some grab-and-go suggestions are offered to help you get started in adapting or designing training materials.



# Reading

Reading is the ability to find, understand and use information presented through words, symbols and images.

## Why are Reading Skills Important?

The changing labour market and advances in technology require reading skills for learning and work. Strong reading skills allow you to do your job and to work safely and efficiently. You use reading skills to learn other skills, for example, by reading online learning resources. Reading is also important in day-to-day activities, for example, to understand road signs or to follow the instructions on a medicine bottle.

**Reading Components**

1. Identify the task that requires you to read
2. Identify the information contained in the document(s)
3. Make connections between different parts of the document(s)
4. Understand and apply the information
5. Evaluate the document(s)
6. Reflect on the document(s)

*Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success (p. 15)*

| Sector | Workplace Examples |
|---|---|
| Construction | Ironworkers read their organizations' health and safety policies to be familiar with safety standards and job task procedures. |
| Manufacturing | Machine Operators synthesize information from a measuring machine manual and a laser cutter manual to learn how to complete a job. |
| Tourism | Floor Managers read e-mails from customers, co-workers and managers. For example, they read customer requests for changes to event schedules and supplier responses to enquiries about equipment rentals. |
| Health Care | Health Care Assistants read short reports from nurses and other health care assistants to learn about incidents that occurred during earlier shifts. |

## Transitioning from Essential Skills to Skills for Success

The most significant change to Reading in the Skills for Success framework is that it now includes elements of Document Use, which was considered a separate skill in the Essential Skills model.

Document Use has been relocated and is now embedded in the skills of Reading, Writing and Numeracy. This update reflects the frequently integrated nature of these skills in work, learning and life contexts. Recent international literacy and skill surveys, such as the 2012 PIACC framework, have similarly grouped Document Use and Reading together as "literacy skills".

The following table shows how Document Use has been integrated within Reading. The Skills for Success column on the left identifies the components and subcomponents of Reading that include elements of Document Use (identified in red within the *Research Report*). The Essential Skills column on the right lists the Document Use tasks from the original model that are relevant to Reading. Practitioners can use these cues to plan where to integrate existing Document Use materials into Reading instruction.

| Document Use Integration | |
|---|---|
| **Skills for Success**<br>*Reading components and subcomponents that include some Document Use elements* | **Essential Skills**<br>*Reading-related Document Use tasks from the original model* |
| 2. Identify the information contained in the document(s)<br>• Locate key information in various types of documents (e.g., tables, charts, maps, articles, magazines, and books)<br>• Use methods such as scanning, skimming to identify key information<br>• Look through multiple pieces of information contained in documents<br>• Pull out relevant information from documents<br><br>3. Make connections between different parts of the document(s)<br>• Connect different parts of the document(s), including continuous and non-continuous texts<br><br>4. Understand and apply the information<br>• Understand the information in the context of the whole document(s)<br>• Make inferences to obtain the correct information<br>• Compare and contrast information<br>• Sort information<br>• Understand the purpose of the document(s)<br><br>*Research Report to Support the Launch of Skills for Success (p. 15)* | • read signs, labels or lists<br>• read completed forms containing check boxes, numerical entries, phrases, addresses, sentences or texts of a paragraph or more<br>• read tables, schedules and other table-like text (e.g., read work shift schedules)<br>• obtain specific information from graphs or charts<br>• interpret information on graphs or charts<br>• interpret scale drawings (e.g., blueprints or maps)<br>• read assembly drawings (e.g., those found in service and parts manuals)<br>• read schematic drawings (e.g., electrical schematics)<br>• obtain information from sketches, pictures or icons (e.g., computer toolbars)<br>• interpret X-rays<br><br>*Reader's Guide to Essential Skills Profiles (p. 25)* |

Practitioners can also use the reading components to guide and structure how they deliver instruction. The reading components are process-oriented, identifying the key skills and steps required to complete a reading task. This is a helpful update since the Essential Skills framework did not provide processes for a learner or practitioner to follow.

## Evidence-Based Instructional Strategies

The following instructional strategies have been selected to highlight established or promising practices within the Skills for Success field and/or significant research that supports the instruction of reading skills.

### 1 Authentic Documents

Authentic documents are real-world documents that exist outside of the training room. They are workplace materials that workers use on the job and practitioners incorporate in training to contextualize learning and engage participants.

Authentic documents include the emails, standard operating procedures (SOPs), entry forms, schedules, diagrams, codes, regulations, schematics, tables, reports and graphs that workers use on the job. Workers navigate documents to locate information to complete a task, learn something new, follow a procedure and so on.

Given the work-oriented nature of the Skills for Success framework, the incorporation of authentic documents has been a mainstay of reading instruction.

*Instructional Strategies:*

- Choose authentic documents that relate to participants' career goals. Participants are more engaged and motivated when materials are contextualized to the workplace they are in or to the occupation they are interested in.
- Use authentic documents to replicate worker tasks. Identify how a worker would use the document on the job. Then guide participants through the reading components and processes, tackling the reading task as a worker would. Use the document as an opportunity to incorporate other Skills for Success, such as writing, numeracy and communication, helping participants to build multiple skills and apply them to authentic tasks.
- Include a variety of document types (e.g., entry forms, log books, schedules, health and safety information, diagrams, graphs and charts, etc.) with a variety of document structure features (e.g., headings, subheadings, bolding, colour, etc.). Teach participants about the role of these features and how to navigate different types of documents.

**Engagement**



Integrate multiple Skills for Success into programming model to reflect the interactive nature of skills.

*Implementation Guidance (p. 105)*

**Note**: See Approach #2 in Section 2 to learn more about contextualizing instruction across skills, sectors and audiences.




**Practitioner Competency Framework**

- SFS 2.2 Contextualizes Skills for Success training to make learning relevant and practical
- SFS 3.1.4 Integrates authentic documents into reading activities, including culturally and contextually relevant documents
- SFS 3.1.5 Provides instruction on structures, features and purposes of different types of documents
- SFS 3.1.6 Provides instruction on strategies for navigating documents through the use of features and structures

## 2 Foundational Reading Skills

Participants in Skills for Success training programs have a wide variety of educational backgrounds, skill levels and learning needs. Practitioners should avoid assuming that participants have the foundational reading skills they need to complete reading tasks in training and on the job.

Foundational reading skills include the four components of alphabetics (including phonemic awareness and word analysis), fluency, vocabulary and comprehension.

*Instructional Strategies:*

- Use diagnostic tools to pinpoint participants' abilities in alphabetics, fluency, vocabulary and comprehension. It is important to assess participants' abilities in each of these areas in order to identify what they already know as well as what they need to work on during training. These profiles give practitioners valuable information to prioritize instruction and address individual needs.
- Provide explicit instruction on each of the foundational components as needed. For alphabetics, teach the relationship between letters and sounds. Fluency can be increased by reading the same text multiple times, including orally. Improve vocabulary by providing participants with the opportunity to use new words many times and to process them deeply. Research shows that improving alphabetics, fluency and vocabulary will ultimately lead to increased comprehension (Kruidenier et al., 2010, pp. 8-9).

- Adapt your instruction of foundational reading skills for English language learners (ELL). Generally, participants who are ELL benefit from the same instruction as native speakers, but differentiating your approach can help maximize skill gains. For example, using bilingual instruction and cooperative learning are proven techniques. Consider similarities and differences between English and participants' native language(s) in the way you approach foundational reading skills (Kruidenier et al., 2010, pp. 8-9).

Under represented Groups

**Engagement**

Align learning content and delivery modes with unique learner needs, objectives, skill levels and contexts.

*Implementation Guidance (p.104)*




**Practitioner Competency Framework**

- SFS 3.1.1 Provides instruction on foundational reading skills and knowledge as required
- SFS 3.1.3 Integrates context-specific language and vocabulary-building activities into reading instruction

## 3 Systematic Reading Strategies

Systematic reading strategies are step-by-step models participants can follow to successfully find and interpret information in text. Research shows that participants' reading skills improve when they are taught explicit strategies on how to approach reading tasks and are provided with frequent opportunities to practice these strategies.

*Instructional Strategies:*

- Use guided instruction to build learner autonomy, moving from direct teaching to increasingly independent learning. Duke and Pearson (2002) recommend a "gradual release of responsibility" with five components (p. 210):

1. An explicit description of the strategy and when and how it should be used.
2. Teacher and/or student modeling of the strategy in action.
3. Collaborative use of the strategy in action.
4. Guided practice using the strategy with gradual release of responsibility.
5. Independent use of the strategy.

- Teach participants how to skim and scan while reading. Participants with low reading skills may get stuck on carefully reading each word. Instead, provide instruction on how to skim read for the gist and how to scan texts to locate specific information. Discuss and model how these strategies can be applied to reading tasks at work and in training.

**Engagement**

Create safe learning spaces by leveraging the social emotional Skills for Success to build learners' self-efficacy, autonomy and confidence.

*Implementation Guidance (p. 109)*

and accurately by providing instruction on question structure. For instance, teach participants about question words and identifying the type of requested information. Teach question answering strategies that incorporate the four constructs of question complexity: type of requested information, type of match, type of processing and competing information (Lew & Hardt, 2011).




**Practitioner Competency Framework**

- SFS 2.6.3 Guides the learning process with step-by-step processes, templates, demonstrations and/or models for participants to follow
- SFS 3.1.2 Provides instruction on reading strategies to help participants respond systematically to comprehension questions
- SFS 3.1.7 Provides instruction on question structure and determining requested information
- DELIVER 1.3.3 Fosters independence by reducing the amount of support provided as participants gain ability, confidence and readiness to become independent

## Assessment Considerations

Reading assessments typically require participants to complete a series of reading tasks of varying complexity. Correct and incorrect answers can be scored objectively. There is a rich body of national and international research to support the creation of reading assessments with demonstrated reliability and validity (e.g., PIACC and TOWES).